

Unit 3 teacher notes

Sequencing across the three-week block

Five topics over three weeks divides naturally as 3.1 and 3.2 in Week 6, 3.3 and 3.4 in Week 7, and 3.5 plus the assessment in Week 8.

Topic 3.1 must come first and must not be rushed. It establishes that effectiveness has competing definitions, and every later topic leans on that. A cohort that leaves 3.1 with one tidy definition will read the rest of the unit as a list of tips.

If the block is compressed, compress 3.5. Its content is the most straightforward and the most recoverable later, whereas 3.4 needs the delivery activity to land at all.

The misconceptions that recur

Five, each named inside the topic that corrects it.

"An effective teacher is one whose class gets high marks." The Junaid and Shazia vignette is built to defeat this. Do not resolve it for the class; let the three definition groups in the Topic 3.1 activity produce three different appraisals and let the class sit with the result.

"Personality is fixed." This one stops trainees working on anything, so it is worth time. The strongest counter is the failure-mode column: if more of a trait can be worse, then "having it" was never the goal, and the question becomes which behaviours you enact in role.

"Professional image means expensive clothes." Common in cohorts from lower-income backgrounds and quietly demoralising. The layered diagram exists for this. Be explicit that in most government schools an expensively dressed teacher reads as distant, not professional.

"A good relationship with pupils means being liked." Trainees resist this correction because being liked is pleasant. The useful evidence is their own schooling: ask which teacher they trusted most and whether that teacher was the most likeable one.

"93% of communication is non-verbal." This will be quoted by somebody. Correct it directly. It comes from Mehrabian's 1967 attitude experiments, and repeating it in an assignment is a citation failure as much as a factual one.

Do not let the class settle for the usual replacement either. "The non-verbal channel wins when they disagree" descends from the same experiments, and the topic now marks it explicitly as a practitioner's heuristic rather than a finding. This is the unit's best opportunity to teach citation discipline, because the book applies the rule to itself.

Running the observation tasks

Three practicum tasks in this unit involve observing a serving teacher: the appraisal enquiry in 3.1, the trait observation in 3.2, and the conflict interview in 3.3. Two cautions.

These can read as evaluation of the mentor. Frame them before trainees go out: the task is to understand a system or a practice, not to grade a host teacher who is doing them a favour. A trainee who arrives with a checklist and a clipboard will damage a relationship the placement depends on.

The 3.1 task can surface uncomfortable findings. Asking how teachers are appraised sometimes produces an answer that the appraisal is nominal, or that results are adjusted. Decide in advance how you will handle that in the debrief. The productive framing is what the measure rewards, which is a systems question, rather than what the school is doing wrong, which will get a trainee into trouble.

The activity that most often goes wrong

The Topic 3.4 delivery activity, in which one instruction is delivered four ways, fails if trainees change the words. They will, almost without noticing, because it is very hard to deliver identical words in a flat tone once you know the point.

Intervene by writing the instruction on the board and requiring it verbatim each time. The whole finding depends on the words being constant, and the moment a group varies them the observer attributes the difference to the wording and the point is lost.

Practical work

Seating-plan gaze map (Week 7). The Topic 3.4 transfer task is the single most reliably useful thing in this unit. Nearly every trainee discovers a neglected zone. Collect the maps and display a few anonymised; the pattern across a whole cohort is more persuasive than any individual result.

Arrange peer observation pairs in advance, because trainees who have to find an observer usually do not.

Classroom research (Week 8). The Topic 3.5 task requires deciding the evidence in advance. That is the part to police. Ask each trainee to tell you their measure **before** they teach the lesson, and record it. In the debrief, ask specifically who found that their change did not work, and treat that answer as the strongest result in the room rather than a disappointment. If nobody reports a negative finding across a whole cohort, the measures were chosen after the fact.

Trait self-audit (Week 6). The Topic 3.2 material supports a private self-audit against the seven traits. Keep it private and do not collect it; a self-audit that will be read becomes a self-presentation.

Marking the unit assessment

The bank is on the unit assessment page with model answers and analytic rubrics.

Two notes. The RRQ mark schemes are point-by-point and total more than a single paper should carry; select from them. And the ERQ rubrics cap a response that does not reach "Adequate" on the analysis or evaluation criterion at 10 out of 20. At this level the most common strong-looking weak answer is a fluent description of all five roles, or all seven traits, that never analyses or judges anything. The cap is what stops it scoring like a good answer.

ERQ 1 is the integrative item and is the best single indicator of whether the unit landed, because it cannot be answered from any one topic.

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